

Birds

This month it's the crow – *Corvus Corone*



As the RSPB says, the all-black carrion crow is one of the cleverest, most adaptable of our birds. If you want to see this in action watch the 4 minutes of *Are Crows the Ultimate Problem Solvers? Inside the Animal Mind/BBC Earth* on YouTube.

And Aesop's fable about the thirsty crow – a thirsty crow wanted water from a pitcher. He filled it with stones to raise the water level!

Fairly solitary, not so gregarious as other corvids and usually found alone or in pairs, although they may form occasional flocks in winter roosts.

They're scavengers by nature and make the most of stealing eggs and young birds, small mammals as well as insects, earthworms, fruits, etc. They frequent sites occupied by humans in order to feed on household waste - once they learn when it's safe.



They compete with and harass other birds of prey for their kills. Once watched a couple of crows less than a metre away from and never taking their eyes off a Peregrine with its kill - until the Peregrine moved off and left the half-eaten pigeon.

In the breeding season they will harass, forming groups to do so, predators, such as Red Kites, who invade their territory thereby threatening them or their young.



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The crow's nests on the Stavros S Niarchos. Is it really 17 years ago since we climbed up there?

The breeding season



Not quite the same as those crow's nests the crows usually build their bulky stick nests in a tall tree or some other high-up place.



The brown speckled blue or greenish eggs are incubated for up to 3 weeks by the female - who is fed by the male.



The young fledge after another 29-30 days.

Sometimes offspring from the previous years stay around to help rear the hatchlings. Just like teenagers they look for food and help their parents feed the new brood!

The crow's call

Noisy with a croaked *kraa* it perches on a high vantage point and bows its head and neck with each caw.



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Myths and folklore

- ❖ The Celts believed the crow accompanied the sun on its nocturnal journey (supposedly through hell) and was therefore evil.



- ❖ The Greek God Apollo sent a white crow to spy on his lover Coronis. When the crow returned with bad news, Apollo scorched its feathers black.
- ❖ Apollo also sent a crow to bring him some water but the crow spotted a fig tree and stayed there until the fruit had ripened. It was punished for its disobedience and egotism.
- ❖ In the bible Noah sent out 2 birds to search for land after the flood, only the dove returned. The crow was deemed too selfish.
- ❖ A crow that appears in your life usually means you should be thinking more thoroughly about your life. It's usually a symbol of bad luck and death, or, on the other hand a symbol of magic and mysteries.

A murder of Crows



Well stone the crows, we're halfway through the month and all the posters aren't up yet!

Australian in origin the phrase was popularized in the 50s and 60s by the comedian Tony Hancock who shortened it to **Stone me!**